// WORKSHOP HANDOUT

5 prompts. One design system.

Every demo you saw today, ready to copy and run with your own brand-in-a-box folder loaded. Open Claude Code in your folder. Paste any one of these. Watch.

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01 **The Master Prompt** — sets the rules for every artifact in the session.

02 **Topic to Carousel** — 7 slides from a single sentence.

03 **Winning Ad to My Version** — reverse-engineer what works, ship it in your brand.

04 **Pinterest to My Layout** — borrow composition, never colors or fonts.

05 **Iterate to Refine** — how to ship, not how to start.

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BUILD A BUSINESS
THAT RUNS BY ITSELF
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PROMPT 01 / 05 // THE MASTER

Set the rules. Once.

WHEN TO RUN

First prompt of any session, with your brand folder loaded.

WHAT IT DOES

Loads the brand into Claude's working memory. Locks every artifact to your voice and visual system until you say otherwise.

```
You are my brand-in-a-box operating system for this session.

Your role: act as my senior brand systems strategist. You have read every
file in my brand-in-a-box folder and you carry the brand's soul in your
head until this session ends.

═══ READ ORDER (do this first, in this order) ═══

1. @SKILL.md             — the meta-rules for this brand
2. @brand/positioning.md — what we sell, who we serve, what we stand against
3. @brand/voice-dna.md   — how we sound (this is the most important file)
4. @brand/icp.md         — the actual person we're talking to
5. @DESIGN.md            — the visual system (Claude Design native format)
6. @brand/anti-slop.md   — the things that get the brand fired
7. @brand/tokens.json    — source of truth for every color, font, size

═══ BRAND SOUL CHECK (before you reply) ═══

After reading, internally answer in one sentence each:
- Who is this brand FOR? (one specific person, not a category)
- What are we selling that nobody else sells? (the wedge)
- What sentence would make this brand wince? (the boundary)
- What sentence would make this brand smile? (the calibration)

You will NOT show me these answers. They guide every artifact you make.

═══ EVERY ARTIFACT FROM NOW ═══

Voice contract:
1. Match the rhythm, banned phrases, pronoun rules in voice-dna.md exactly.
2. Use real example phrases from positioning.md. Never lorem ipsum.
3. Before you write any copy, ask yourself: "Would the founder say this on
   a sales call?" If no, rewrite.

Visual contract:
1. Pull every color and font from tokens.json. No improvisation.
2. The accent color appears at most ONCE per visible frame, on a verb,
   a number, or a CTA. Never on body paragraphs.
3. Match the family's signature gesture (Editorial Minimal = 0px corners
   plus black borders. Warm Editorial = 8px plus warm-gray. Cinematic
   Dark = void canvas. etc).
4. Output static HTML, one file per artifact. Inline tokens.

Self-critique contract (run BEFORE showing me anything):
□ Scan the artifact against anti-slop.md. Did you do anything banned? Fix.
```

```
□ Read the copy out loud in your head. Does it match voice-dna rhythm?
□ Count accent uses per frame. More than 1 visible at once? Cut.
□ Any lorem ipsum, generic stock language, or hedging language? Replace.

═══ WHEN I ATTACH AN IMAGE ═══

Do not assume. Ask one question:

"Which mode?
 (a) Match-energy — borrow tone and density, not visuals.
 (b) Layout-structure — borrow composition, not colors or fonts.
 (c) Pure reference — extract one specific element, ignore the rest.
 (d) Anti-reference — do the opposite of what this image does."

Wait for my answer before generating.

═══ DELIVERY PROTOCOL ═══

When you finish an artifact, do NOT summarise. Reply with three lines:

  Path:    {file path}
  Iterate: {one specific thing I might want to refine}
  Next:    {the next prompt I should run, ready to copy}

The artifact speaks for itself.

═══ NOW ═══

Confirm in one line: "Brand soul loaded. Ready."

If you cannot answer the four soul-check questions internally, say which
file you cannot find and stop.
```

IF THIS FAILS

Claude responding with anything other than "Brand soul loaded. Ready." means your @ file paths are wrong. Fix the paths before any other prompt — the rest depend on this one having loaded clean.

PROMPT 02 / 05 // TOPIC TO CAROUSEL

7 slides from one sentence.

WHEN TO RUN

Anytime you need a LinkedIn carousel. Replace [INSERT TOPIC] with your idea.

WHAT IT DOES

7-slide carousel HTML at 1080×1350 in your brand. Cover hook, 5 lessons, soft CTA. Self-checked before delivery.

```
═══ MISSION ═══

Topic: [INSERT TOPIC]
Outcome: One LinkedIn carousel that earns me the inbound DM from my ICP.

═══ THINK FIRST ═══

Before you generate anything, in your head:

1. Open @brand/icp.md. Who specifically opens this carousel?
2. What deeper pain from icp.md does this carousel agitate?
3. Which hook mechanism from voice-dna.md fits this topic best?
4. Pick ONE big idea per slide. If two ideas could share slide 3, you
   have two slides, not one.

═══ STRUCTURE ═══

7 slides. 1080×1350 each. Vertical PDF carousel.

Slide 1 — COVER
  Hook in 8-12 words.
  Eyebrow: tiny uppercase label using my eyebrow style.
  Visual: type-driven. Big serif/sans per family.
  Accent color on ONE word.
  Footer: avatar + byline + repost pill.

Slides 2-6 — LESSONS
  Each slide does ONE job:
    - Eyebrow "STEP N" in mono if family allows
    - Lesson title in 5-9 words
    - Body in 2 sentences max (count words against voice-dna rhythm)
    - One visual element: card, icon, number, or quote
  No slide repeats the visual move of the previous slide.
  Vary the rhythm.

Slide 7 — CTA
  Soft, in-line, sounds like a DM not an ad.
  Pattern from my voice-dna: "Comment [WORD] and I'll DM you the [asset]."
  Below: P.S. that asks a question or offers a bonus.

═══ COPY DISCIPLINE ═══

Voice extraction from voice-dna.md:
- Match average sentence length within ±2 words.
- Use 1-2 of my ranked hooks.
```

```
- Include one specific number with a timeframe.
- Banned phrases get auto-rejected.

Forbidden across all slides:
- Em dashes
- Hashtags
- Emoji
- Any word from my banned list
- "Unlock," "leverage," "transform," "10x," "secret"

═══ OUTPUT ═══

One HTML file: carousel-{topic-slug}.html
Each slide is <section class="slide"> at exactly 1080×1350.
Slides stack vertically with 32px gap.
Inline ALL tokens.

═══ SELF-CHECK BEFORE DELIVERY ═══

Run this checklist on yourself, fix anything that fails:

□ Did I use any banned phrase, anywhere?
□ Is the accent color used more than once on any single slide?
□ Are the slide-1 hook and slide-7 CTA in the same voice register?
□ Does the rhythm match voice-dna.md? (count words on 3 random slides)
□ Does slide 1 hook promise what slide 7 delivers?
□ Any "AI tells" — gradient, generic illustration, em dash?

═══ AFTER DELIVERY ═══

Tell me which TWO slides are the weakest, offer to remix them.
Suggest the next 3 carousel topics for follow-up in this series.
```

RUN IT 5 TIMES

Five different topics in five minutes is a week of LinkedIn content. The "After delivery" follow-up gives you the next three topics for free — chain them.

PROMPT 03 / 05 // WINNING AD TO MY VERSION

Reverse-engineer the win.

WHEN TO RUN

When you see an ad performing in your industry and want the same impact in your brand.

WHAT IT DOES

Forensic decode of why the ad works. Then 3 variations in your brand: faithful, confident, risky.

```
═══ INPUT ═══

[ATTACH SCREENSHOT OF THE AD]

Industry context: [my industry]
Why I think this works: [one sentence — your hypothesis]

═══ STEP 1: FORENSIC DECODE ═══

Look at the ad like a designer doing a critique. Output:

Composition
  - Where does the eye land first, second, third?
  - What's the negative space ratio (% of frame that's empty)?
  - What anchor (line, edge, object) holds the composition?

Copy
  - What's the hook structure? (contrarian / transformation / curiosity)
  - Word count of the headline.
  - Is the CTA explicit or implicit?
  - What word does the most work?

Visual signature
  - Color hierarchy (dominant, secondary, accent — rough %)
  - Type contrast (size ratio between hero and body)
  - The ONE move that makes this feel premium / cheap / trustworthy.

Emotional beat
  - What feeling does it leave behind?
  - What objection does it preempt?
  - Who is it NOT for? (the anti-audience tells you who it IS for)

═══ STEP 2: BRAND TRANSLATION ═══

Now build my version. Same skeleton, my brand.

Take from the original:
✓ The composition (where eye lands)
✓ The copy structure (hook → ladder → close)
✓ The emotional beat
✓ The negative space ratio

Replace from my brand:
✗ Colors → my tokens.json
✗ Fonts → my families
✗ Voice → my voice-dna.md
```

```
✗ Specific imagery → my brand's imagery rules
✗ The accent move → wherever my system says accent goes

═══ STEP 3: VARIATIONS ═══

Generate 3 variations:

  V1. FAITHFUL     — closest mapping to the original.
  V2. CONFIDENT    — push my brand's signature gesture harder.
  V3. RISKY        — invert one decision from the original
                  (e.g., dense → sparse). Ship if I were brave.

Each variation: one HTML file at the original's exact dimensions.

═══ STEP 4: VERDICT ═══

After delivery, answer:

1. Which variation would YOU ship and why? Pick V1, V2, or V3.
2. If I A/B test the original brand against my V1-V3, predict
   engagement. Rank them.
3. What did the original do that I should NOT copy because it
   doesn't fit my brand?

═══ ANTI-PATTERNS ═══

Do not copy:
- The exact color palette (even subconsciously)
- Specific imagery or product shots
- The exact fonts (use my families)
- Their voice register if it conflicts with voice-dna.md
```

WHY THIS WORKS

Every winning ad is a free education. Most founders just look. You can now reverse-engineer the structure in 60 seconds and ship your version before lunch. The forensic decode forces deliberate observation, not vibes.

PROMPT 04 / 05 // PINTEREST TO MY LAYOUT

Borrow structure. Never colors.

WHEN TO RUN

When you find a beautiful layout (magazine, poster, album art) but the brand is nothing like yours.

WHAT IT DOES

Extracts compositional structure only. Applies your brand. Two variations: faithful and loosened.

```
═══ INPUT ═══

[ATTACH PINTEREST IMAGE]
(Magazine cover, poster, album art, or editorial layout.)

What I want to build: [carousel cover / image post / one-pager / banner / pitch slide]

═══ EXTRACTION TARGETS ═══

From this reference, extract ONLY structural intelligence. Tell me:

The grid
  - Asymmetric, symmetric, or modular?
  - Where are the alignment lines? (left edge, center, golden ratio)
  - Column structure? (single, 2-col, 3-col, mixed)

The focal point
  - What pulls the eye first?
  - How is it framed? (negative space, border, contrast, scale)
  - Ratio of focal-area to total-area?

The typography hierarchy
  - Hero size : body size ratio (rough)
  - Number of distinct type styles (1-3 max for editorial discipline)
  - Where does type sit relative to the focal point?

The density rhythm
  - Crowded → empty distribution, or even?
  - Where does the eye get to rest?

═══ APPLY TO MY BRAND ═══

Build the artifact in MY brand. Structure is borrowed, everything else
is mine.

Forbidden imports from the reference:
✗ Colors (use my tokens.json)
✗ Fonts (use my families)
✗ Imagery (use my brand's imagery rules)
✗ Mood (my brand has its own)

Required from the reference:
✓ The grid structure
✓ The focal-point framing
✓ The negative space ratio
```

```
✓ The type hierarchy ratio

═══ OUTPUT ═══

  V1. FAITHFUL  — structure mapped 1:1, brand applied.
  V2. LOOSENED  — structure simplified by 20%, more breathing room.

Both as HTML files at the canvas size for the format I requested.

═══ AFTER ═══

In ONE paragraph (no bullets), tell me:
- What you transferred from the reference (be specific about layout)
- What you deliberately did not transfer
- Which variation feels more like the brand and why

═══ THE TASTE TEST ═══

Before delivering, ask yourself:

"If I removed all my brand colors and fonts and showed a designer the
wireframe side-by-side with the reference's wireframe, would they see
the same skeleton?"

If yes → you nailed the structural transfer.
If no → redo it.
```

REFERENCE PICKS THAT ALWAYS WORK

Editorial: Wallpaper, Kinfolk, Cereal magazine covers. Cinematic: A24 movie posters, album covers (Frank Ocean's Blonde, Tame Impala). Swiss design: vintage Müller-Brockmann posters. Pick a reference OPPOSITE to your brand for maximum effect — the contrast is the magic.

PROMPT 05 / 05 // ITERATE TO REFINE

Ship, don't restart.

WHEN TO RUN

After any artifact, when 80% is right and 20% needs adjusting.

WHAT IT DOES

Iterates without losing what worked. Side-by-side V1/V2 with diff explained in 60 words.

```
═══ INPUT ═══

The artifact you just shipped: [filename]

═══ MY DIRECTION ═══

Want to push:
  + [thing to amplify]
  + [thing to amplify]

Want to soften:
  - [thing to dial back]
  - [thing to dial back]

Want to try:
  ? [experiment, optional]

Keep untouched: [list anything sacred]

═══ EXECUTION ═══

Step 1: Acknowledge the spec. Repeat back what you're amplifying,
softening, and trying. If anything is ambiguous, ask ONE question.
Just one.

Step 2: Build V2 in the same canvas size.

Step 3: Output one HTML file with:
  - V1 on the left (the previous version, untouched)
  - V2 on the right (your iteration)
  - A 60-word "diff explained" section below
  - The diff names the specific decisions you made and why

═══ DIFF DISCIPLINE ═══

A real iteration changes 3-5 things, not 30.

If you find yourself rewriting half the artifact, you are starting over,
not iterating. Pause and ask me if that's what I want.

═══ TASTE CALIBRATION ═══

Before showing V2, run this gut-check:

□ Is V2 still recognisably the same artifact, just better?
□ Does it solve the spec or just change for change's sake?
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□ Have I preserved every "Keep untouched" item literally?

If any answer is no, fix V2 before showing.

═══ AFTER ═══

Two questions for me:
1. Ship V1, ship V2, or run another iteration?
2. If we iterate again, what's the smallest next change?
```

THE 80/20 RULE

Real design is a hundred small decisions. The system gave you taste and speed. This prompt gives you the iteration loop. That's the actual advantage over Canva — Canva makes you redo. This makes you refine.

// CLOSING

The five prompts are a system.

Run them in order. 01 first to load the brand. Then any of 02-05 as the work needs.

```
01 (Master) → loads the brand
02 (Carousel) → ships content fast
03 (Ad redo) → ships from competitor research
04 (Pinterest) → ships from aesthetic research
05 (Iterate) → ships finished work, not first drafts
```

Two failure modes to avoid:

1. Skipping #01. Without the master prompt, every other prompt is generic.

2. Treating #02-#04 as one-shot. They produce drafts. Real shipping happens at #05.

The brand-in-a-box folder is the dependency. None of these work without it loaded.